



Earth 2.0

NASA's Kepler programme finds us a sister planet. All we need to do is get there and start populating it: <http://dgit.in/sisterplanet>

500 Days of Night

A robotic miniature space shuttle on a classified mission marked its 500th day in orbit recently: <http://dgit.in/X37B500>

Tales from the Void

Prakrit Dhondiyal

readersletters@thinkdigit.com

J "You're not what I expected, to be honest." Godric put his coffee down in response.

"That's alright, you're not what I expected, either," said Godric, grinning and leaned back in his chair. Celeste laughed. She had an unusual laugh. Godric liked it.

She's much smarter than she actually lets on.

It had been a while since he could sit down and have an intellectual conversation with someone. It felt good. He could feel his brain cells grinding through the settled rust after all this time.

"Are you still with me?"

Godric shook his thoughts aside.

"My apologies. I have a very slippery mind."

She waved it off. "I understand. My brother Deigratia is exactly the same. I'm used to it. But tell me –" She leaned in over the table, "What are you working on? It's clear that you're very unlike the other pretentious programmers here. I find it hard to believe that someone who spends so much time in his own world has nothing worth talking about."

Godric sighed. "I've been through way too many rejections from up top, to be frank. This place doesn't open up to new ideas." Celeste chuckled.

"Sounds more like you're in a rut."

"You could say that."

"Alright then – throw an idea my way. Maybe I can tell you where you're going wrong."

"I don't know... My ideas border on the radical. And over-the-top. And honestly, just a little insane."

"I like a little insanity, now and then."

Godric looked at the eager expression on Celeste's face, quietly contemplating her suggestion.

"Come on, tell me."

Godric gave in. "Alright. There is a program I'm working on. I'm stuck, but I'll show you what I have."

"Now that sounds like a plan."

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"Endless?"

"Well, not really endless. But it does have a virtually infinite number of possible outcomes. The program analyses over seven hundred trillion probabilities for every scenario, and that was based on the last time I tested it. I've been tweaking the source code to make it more efficient, and above all, make the program a lot more realistic. While other computer programs have the potential to answer questions that they are asked, getting them to respond and continue after the question to formulate an entire conversation like a person does, hasn't been this close to being possible. Interacting with this program is much like talking to a physical being. It lives, learns, and adapts at almost the same speed as one of us would."

"And you made this?"

"Well, yes. I tinker with the program, occasionally. The only thing is, I fail to see how this would help me in game design. Why

would anyone care about a superiorly interactive computer program? Well, unless they're very, very lonely."

Celeste skimmed through the endless lines of code, at a speed common to programmers of her calibre. She had to admit, it was brilliant.

"Well, what's the problem, then?"

Godric shuffled in his chair uncomfortably. "Battlestar Games hasn't been very agreeable when it comes to my ideas. This isn't what we do."

"No, Battlestar simply revamps old successful games and releases them to the masses."

"It's what the people want!"

"You know better." Celeste actually looked a little angry, now.

"You shouldn't give up on something close to you simply because you're worried about failing."

She turned and walked out of Godric's room. Godric followed.

"I'm sorry. I didn't mean to offend you."

Celeste sighed. "I'm not offended. Just disappointed."

To Godric, that seemed worse.

"You have some great ideas. And you're smart. Don't waste your talent because you think people won't agree with you. Make them agree. Do you remember the old days?"

"What old days?"

"When gaming was about fresh new ideas. New technology. Gaming was a product of cutting-edge technology."

"When it was responsible for uniting the planet."

"Yes!"

"20 years before I was born."

Celeste waved his comment off. "I mean what we've read. When gaming became our lives. Games were fresh, innovative."

"Downright kloniko. Yes, I do know what you mean."

"Exactly. You're not the only one in a rut, Godric. The word's been in a rut for nearly a decade. We need something new. And this could be it."

Godric fell silent for a few moments, mulling over her suggestion. He agreed with her about the world being in a rut. He'd thought about it himself, usually with close friends over a mug of ale. But Godric had never had the hubris of considering leading the change himself.

"You really think so?" he asked, quietly.

"Well, no, not really." She grinned. "But anything's possible. Why disregard the dream simply because it's difficult?"

Godric laughed. "You're insane."

"Told you." She smiled back.

J What's taking them so long?

Godric straightened his tie and paced the corridor outside the Praetor's office.

I should have pitched it better. Kuhr'vat!

"Godric. Relax."

Godric stopped and glared at Cain, "You could have been more supportive in there, you know."

Cain lay back on the recliner, seemingly unconcerned. "Hey, I said it's kloniko, didn't I?"

"Kloniko. Sure. Why would I be worried? It has your stamp of 'kloniko'! That must have swayed them, for sure." Godric snapped